Feeding the Moonfish

By Barbara Wiechmann

EDEN: You want a Bud?

MARTIN: Who gave you beer?

EDEN: I brought two Buds-one for you and one for me.

MARTIN: You shouldn't be stealing beer from the restaurant.

EDEN: God. It's just a coupla beers.

MARTIN: Doesn't matter.

EDEN: All right. All right. but it's no big crime to drink a beer with me. I ain't no alchy or nothin so you don't have to worry I'm gonna throw up all over you or pass out or somethin. I just thought you might get hot out here that's all. *(She hands him the beer.)*

MARTIN: All right. Thank you. *(He starts to pull the beer tab.)*

INTRODUCTION

EDEN: Feeding the Moonfish

MARTIN: by Barbara Weichmann

EDEN: You might wanna be careful.

MARTIN: You shook this up? What are you giving me shook-up beer for?

EDEN: I didn't shake it up. I don't even know if it is shook up. I just was saying that it *could be*.. I was only doin you the courtesy of warnin you.

MARTIN: O.K. O.K.

EDEN: I like the nighttime. Did you ever notice at night the way you can open up to people. You can open -right up the way you never could in the daytime?

MARTIN: I don't know.

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EDEN: I think I come out at night-you know-like a creature, a sci-fi creature.

MARTIN: Yeah. You're a creature all right. *(looks back down at the lake)*

EDEN: You like them fish don't you?

MARTIN: This place used to be fantastic. There was a marina. Men would come here and fish. .

EDEN: They fished for the moonfish? They ate the moonfish?

MARTIN: Sharks. They fished for sharks.

EDEN: Sharks.

MARTIN: They hunted em. Took their boats through the channel to the ocean and hunted em. They had contests. I watched them haul em in off their boats an dump em on the dock. Hammerheads, tigers, gray nurses. They slaughtered em.

EDEN: Yeah?

MARTIN: They dumped em in piles and left em. Bellies up, hooks in their mouths, piled to the sun.

EDEN: That's it? What else?

MARTIN: Nothing.

EDEN *(pause):* What do you think people do in prison?

MARTIN: What?

EDEN: My mom's in Sing Sing. Arrested for my dad's murder. She and my Grandma beat him to death.

MARTIN: Your mom's really in jail?

EDEN: Do you think she's having an O.K. time behind bars? I brought her some stuff to make an afghan with but they took away the crochet needles. They said they was lethal weapons. I hope she ain't too bored. She don't know what to do without something in her hands.

MARTIN: She beat your dad to death.

EDEN: She tried. My grandma's the one that killed him. That dealt the actual death

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blow.

MARTIN: Your grandma killed him?

EDEN: She sure did.

MARTIN: Why'd she do it?

EDEN: He used to beat my mom on a semi-regular basis, an this time she was fighting for her life-right? He was choking her. It wasn't even like she had time to think of possible consequences or nothing-she had no choice. She was makin the best of the situation. She found her only opportunity, grabbed the waffle iron with her one free hand, and beamed him with it. Then she called Gram to help her come finish.

MARTIN: He beat you too?

EDEN: Naah. He couldn't beat me-he weren't my blood dad. Just her he beat.

MARTIN: Don't it bother you?

EDEN: Well, what do you think, you must be a moron or something. Wouldn't it upset you? So I'm in homeroom and this announcement comes over the P.A. "Eden Banaglione please report to the front office." Like that-so right away the entire student body of my homeroom thinks it's got to do with me taking these pills in the lav-only they weren't pills they was only Tylenol-so I get to the office and them ugly hairdos are looking at me kinda funny and then they lay it on me- your dad's been bashed to death by a waffle iron, Eden-Your ma's been hauled away to some mental prison, and your grandma's nearly croaked herself in the process of the beating. Now, here's a permission slip, go home honey." Wouldn't it upset you? I mean wouldn't it?

MARTIN: Jesus, calm down, you're all worked up.

EDEN: Of course I'm worked up. Why shouldn't I be? I try to make one single friend and all I get is shutting doors. He don't wanna talk, he don't wanna listen, he just wants to watch these weird fish all night.

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MARTIN: I been listening to you. I'm listening.

EDEN: No. Why should you listen to me. Why should you understand. There's no rational way to account for the disgusting things I've seen in my life.

MARTIN: You can be a drag you know that? Maybe you're just young but even if you ain't lying you ain't the only person's ever seen disgusting things go on in this world, and if you are lying, shit, I could make up stories same as you that'd make your heart bleed into little pieces. So your mom's a little high-strung-I could tell you that I didn't ever have a mom

EDEN: And I could tell you I once worked bachelor parties in order to put food on the table.

MARTIN: I could tell you a brick fell on her head and split her skull wide open one day as she was breast-feeding me

EDEN: I could tell you my grandma was a schizophrenic, I could tell you my father was a junkie and made me his love slave

MARTIN: I could tell you my father slit his throat-what do you want me to do? What's the matter?

EDEN: Nothing.

MARTIN: Look, I'm sorry I ain't been nice to you. I guess I'm just not very nice, you know?

EDEN: Bull

MARTIN: Come on. Come here. Aren't you sleepy? You wanna sleep here or something? *(She shakes her head.)* Here blow your nose. Don't get all snotty on me. You wanna eat something? I got a ham sandwich in the glove compartment.

EDEN: I already ate.

MARTIN: What?

EDEN: Burt's birthday cake.

MARTIN: What, back at the restaurant? You didn't eat any dinner. You didn't eat

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anything healthy. Don't give me that. That's disgusting.

EDEN: I'm not disgusting.

MARTIN: Grow up, I seen you. You let those guys up there-horny old guys-you let them pinch your bun and feed you cake and beer.

EDEN: God, you're such a preacher.

MARTIN: Look, I'm sorry, you shouldn't wear those little cut-off shorts. Your butt hangs out, you know that? I mean don't take this wrong but it's just a plain come-on.

EDEN: Look, you don't have to go playing saint on me or nothing. I ain't your kid or some ugly little sister of yours that can't get a date. I ain't a slut you know.

MARTIN: What does that have to do with anything?

EDEN: You're so cool ain't you? I hear things. What you done to girls. What you done to that girl. You thought she was some dumb slut so it didn't matter none. You thought she had no brains.

MARTIN: What are you even talking about?

EDEN: I hear. I hear. You come out here at night and some girl you think is scum gets drunk and you just let her wander around by herself cause she bugs you. You just let her wander around all miserable and throwing up

MARTIN: People make up stories.

EDEN: All miserable and throwing up and you could care less she gets hurt out here on this rusty old dock. You wouldn't care if she falls in, and can't see and can't swim and screams and screams and panics and you don't even come help her.

MARTIN: Shut up. Shut up.

EDEN: You coulda saved her but you let her drown. You watched her drown I'll bet.

MARTIN: Shut up. *(He moves to strike Eden, but stops himself before his fist makes contact.)* I never touched you.

EDEN: *(Pause)* I know. I know that. It's O.K. You think I'm a slut or something but you know something, it doesn't matter to me. You know that? I don't care you

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think that.

MARTIN: I don't think you're anything.

EDEN: That's O.K. too. You can say that. That's what he said about her. About my ma. That's what he told her. But it weren't true. She was real special to him. She could take him.

MARTIN: What are you talking about?

EDEN: He hit her. He could hit her again and again, and she'd be screaming and throwing furniture, but she could take it. He could do anything and it was O.K. because she loved him so much and she knew how much he loved her cause she was the only one that could take him. You understand? She was special. He didn't do that stuff to no one else. He could fool around on the side but in the long run it was her. She weren't just nothing to him. She was it. She was his living end.

MARTIN: She killed him.

EDEN: Sure. Jealousy. She had to have him for herself completely.

MARTIN: I thought you said she was fighting for her life.

EDEN: Conveniently. She woulda killed him anyway sooner or later. Just to finally have him. She loved him so much. To this day his memory is sacred to her. She's got a framed eight-by-ten of him hanging on the wall of her cell in the slammer. See, their bodies was made to be with each other. That's what I think. Gravity was pulling em to each other. They was real helpless. They couldn't change nothing though. They couldn't *change* see. That's why it don't matter what you think of me

MARTIN: I don't even know you.

EDEN: It don't matter. There ain't nothing you could say or do or think that would change anything so what's to be afraid of right? I'm not afraid of you. It don't matter what you done to some girl. You could burn people's furniture

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cause you didn't like the color, set fire to your neighbor's front lawn and watch the grass grizzle up, you could kill someone -you could never speak another word to me in your life, and it wouldn't matter. I'd still care for you.

MARTIN: You know, I think you're a little sick.

EDEN: That's O.K. too, cause I'm like you. It's nice here, huh? That breeze blowing and all -it's getting cool. That nice breeze, huh? You got such a beautiful face. I like you so much.

MARTIN: You like it here.

EDEN: I like it here with you. To be here with you. It's all beautiful now.

MARTIN: No, it's not the same. *(Pause.)* My dad would take me here.

EDEN: When you were a little kid?

MARTIN: He'd take me here. He'd show me the fish, all the different kinds. The rays. The squirrel fish and the parrot fish.

EDEN: He knew a lot.

MARTIN: At night we'd walk out here. We'd look for the moonfish. They'd come. I couldn't take my eyes off them. All those many fish, swimming in and out of the light, doubling in and off of each other, changing in and out with themselves till they became one silver river wrapped around the dock. Just to get the food. They do that, they become so beautiful just for the food. You wanna know something?

EDEN: What?

MARTIN: The fish talk.

EDEN: The fish talk. The moonfish?

MARTIN: Yes.

EDEN: What do they say?

MARTIN: Different things. What's so funny?

EDEN: You think you're so mysterious. What kind of different things? Will they talk

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to me?

MARTIN: I don't know. I don't think so. *(Eden lies on her back staring up at the sky.)* What are you doing?

EDEN: I'm listening. I'm listening co what them fish are saying.

MARTIN: You can't hear them.

EDEN: You wanna know what I hear, what they're telling me? They're saying: The man in the moon Looked out of the moon Looked out of the moon and said It's time for all of God's children To think about going to bed.

MARTIN: What's that?

EDEN: Shhh. Just be quiet, Martin. Aren't you sleepy now? We should sleep.

MARTIN: Maybe I am.

EDEN: We can sleep out here. We don't have to screw or nothing. I wanna be with you out here sleeping.

MARTIN: Maybe I am sleepy.

EDEN: That's good. We can just be here together. You wanna tell me something while I comb my hair? That's one thing, I comb my hair no matter what, every night one hundred strokes.

MARTIN: All right. Tell you something

EDEN: Tell me anything. Just close your eyes and tell me what you see. Close your eyes.

MARTIN: I'll close them for you.

EDEN: That's good. What are you thinking about now Maryin? What do you see?

MARTIN: I'm dreaming.

EDEN: What?

MARTIN: I'm waiting.

EDEN: What?

MARTIN: Him.

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EDEN: Tell me.

MARTIN: I am waiting for my father. I sleep alone here. Each night I dream and in my dream I see him. Warmer, more real than in life. He watches me sleep and picks me up in his arms like I was a tiny boy and carries me out to the end of the dock. I am weightless. He points to the sky, there is no moon. The water. There is no tide. Only the world, our world in complete stillness. No flux, no pull, no gravity. Just me and him, me and him. We lie on our stomachs, stare down into the dock light, and he calls them. Waiting and waiting, I think "They won't come, there's no moon." But they do come. And they take my breath away. Gigantic pale, and luminous silver, they're kissing the dock with their mouths, feeding on the life there, mingling with the dark water, and I watch till it's like I'm being hypnotized and then I feel him lift me up and up and his arms rock me and his voice in my ear, he tells me, he says to me:

Now it is night we will walk to the end of the pier and watch the moonfish feed because it is night because that's what we do because so much is moved by the pull of the moon.

EDEN: Your dad tells you this?

MARTIN: He lifts me up and up and his kiss goes warm on my cheek, and my forehead and I see the silver of the fish and silver of the razor in his hand, and starting at his ear he slices down, down around the throat, and the red pours Onto the dock and through the planks and onto the moonfish-staining, covering, choking them. His hand goes limp, the razor falls, he crumbles to my feet and noiseless I push the body empty and light into the lake. Waves over him. Billows of blood and water. The downward spiral of flesh, of water. The sleep of water. Then it happens. They come for him. One by one gliding into his pool of blood, testing him with their mouths, each bite making him theirs, pulling him finally down with them into the darkness. They own him now.

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EDEN: They own him now. .

MARTIN: He was so lonely for her. After she left him. He was so lonely. He couldn't sleep in their bedroom anymore. I'd find him in the morning in a ball on the living room floor. That's where he slept. A grown man. Cause he couldn't stand the loneliness.

EDEN: I wouldn't leave you.

MARTIN: He never hit her though. He never touched her, all them times they fought. He couldn't hurt anything. Not a bug, not a lousy fish. Only himself. He could do that.

EDEN: I would stay with you.

MARTIN: I guess it wasn't in him.

EDEN: You got such a nice face.

MARTIN: Sometimes I get this feeling, I'm walking down some road, this thing comes over me. I don't know what it is. I'm just walking and I see someone-some guy, some woman-they've got nothing to do with my life, I see them and I think "I could take him."

EDEN: I like you so much.

MARTIN: I could kill that guy over there. I'd like to kill him. It's not a rational thing. I never killed anyone, but I think I could do it. Maybe I'd like to.

EDEN: I'd still care for you.

MARTIN: You listen to me tell you this. You listen to me, and you just sit there like it was nothing. Like it was natural.

EDEN: Tell me I'm beautiful. *(She places his hand on her hair, he begins to stroke it.)*

MARTIN: You just don't understand anything.

EDEN: Tell me I'm beautiful. *(She takes his hand from her hair and places it on her breast.)*

MARTIN: Like it was natural.

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EDEN: Tell me. *(She takes his hand and places it on her throat-gently but in a choking hold-he holds it there for a moment, then finally begins to stroke her throat.)*

MARTIN: You're beautiful. You're so beautiful.

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AWARDS

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